
CHURN IS DEAD

The Dependency Window Audit

A root-depth diagnostic for the first 90 days

The renewal is decided during onboarding, the last moment CS holds the lever alone. Score every new account on how deeply it rooted before the health flags ever fire.

Scoring: Rate each item 1-5. 1 = not happening, 5 = embedded in operations.

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SECTION 1

1. The Control Ledger

Onboarding is the largest thing in the column CS owns unilaterally. Effort converts directly to outcome only on the owned levers, so senior time must be triaged there.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Owned vs. shared levers are explicitly mapped for the account	A written ledger separates onboarding scope, first outcome, and stakeholder depth (owned) from pricing, expansion, roadmap (shared)	Team behaves as if it influences the whole lifecycle; no distinction between what it controls and what it begs for
Senior CSM time is allocated to the owned column	Most senior hours go to scope, embedding, and threading — the levers where effort converts to outcome	Senior hours burned escalating roadmap requests and price fights that CS cannot win
Onboarding scope is set by CS, not the implementation calendar	Scope defined by depth of dependency required to survive renewal, not by go-live date	Scope compressed to hit a time-to-live target; account handed off as fast as the plan allows
Shared levers are influenced, not owned, and named as such	Roadmap/expansion asks are logged as influence attempts with realistic expectations	Team stakes the renewal on winning a feature or price concession it does not control

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
A documented Control Ledger exists for the account	1-5
Senior time is disproportionately spent on owned levers	1-5
Onboarding scope reflects dependency depth over speed	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 2

2. Rooting, Not Activating

Activation turns your dashboard green; rooting embeds the product into work the customer cannot easily unwind. Roots survive reorgs — logins do not.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
A recurring workflow now runs through the product	A report, process, or system of record the business depends on weekly runs through you	Only logins, seats provisioned, and features toggled are tracked
The rip-out test is genuinely disruptive	Removing the product Monday would force the team to change how it operates	Customer could switch to a spreadsheet and a Slack channel over a weekend
Success is measured by embedding, not usage thresholds	Metrics track whether an operational dependency exists, not login counts or time-to-value	Onboarding measured by time to activation / go-live only
Another system or person expects the output on a cadence	Someone's boss expects a Monday output from the product; downstream systems read from it	Usage is intense but isolated — no external expectation depends on it

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
A recurring, boss-visible workflow runs through the product	1-5
Ripping the product out would disrupt operations	1-5
Success measured by dependency, not activation metrics	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 3

3. The Second-User Test

Single-threaded onboarding is failed onboarding. The dependency only survives the champion's departure if a second team is downstream-dependent by day 90.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
A second team (not individual) is downstream-dependent by day 90	A distinct team inherits data, reports off, or cannot complete its work without the deployment	One enthusiastic champion is the entire footprint
Deployment survives the champion leaving	If the sponsor resigns, another team keeps the product live and needed	Renewal is one resignation away from a competitor discovery call
Multiple stakeholders were engaged during onboarding	Onboarding threaded across teams, not just the buying contact	All engagement routed through a single point of failure
Cross-team dependency is documented and verifiable	The second team's reliance is evidenced by data flows or process ownership	'Broad usage' is assumed but not traced to a specific dependent team

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
A second team is downstream-dependent by day 90	1-5
The deployment survives the champion's departure	1-5
Onboarding was multi-threaded, not single-threaded	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 4

4. The Eleven-Month Echo

Damage from a rushed onboarding surfaces eleven months later. Auditing every flat or churned renewal back to its onboarding reveals what was skipped while the account was fully in your control.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
A documented first outcome was co-signed by the economic buyer	The budget owner signed off on a specific business outcome, not a usage milestone	First value defined by the vendor as an activation event no buyer endorsed
Churned/flat renewals are audited back to onboarding	Every lost or flat account is traced to what was skipped, rushed, or single-threaded at day 90	Post-mortems focus on the save call and month-nine health flag
Onboarding gaps are fed back into the next cohort	Recurring skips (single-threading, no co-signed outcome) get fixed in the playbook	Same onboarding mistakes repeat across cohorts unnoticed
A root-depth score is captured at day 90 for every account	A composite score (teams dependent, outcome co-signed, champion-proof) is recorded and tracked against renewal	Renewal risk assessed only when the health score flips yellow

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
A first outcome was co-signed by the economic buyer	1-5
Lost/flat renewals are traced back to onboarding gaps	1-5
A day-90 root-depth score exists and predicts renewal	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

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Your Scorecard

Dimension	Your Score	Max
1. 1. The Control Ledger	_____	5
2. 2. Rooting, Not Activating	_____	5
3. 3. The Second-User Test	_____	5
4. 4. The Eleven-Month Echo	_____	5
TOTAL	_____	20

Total Score	Assessment	What It Means
16-20	Uncuttable	Embedded, measurable, strategically irreplaceable.
12-15	Defensible	Solid but gaps remain. Focus on lowest dimension.
8-11	Vulnerable	Real risk ahead. Treat as urgent.
4-7	Critical	Cannot survive scrutiny. Major changes needed.

What to do next: Take your lowest-scoring section and build a 30-day action plan. One at a time. Then share this with leadership -- not to ask permission, but to show you know where the gaps are.

A login is fast. A root is slow. Every day you shave off implementation to hit go-live, you borrow against a renewal you will lose in month eleven.

-- Kuber

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